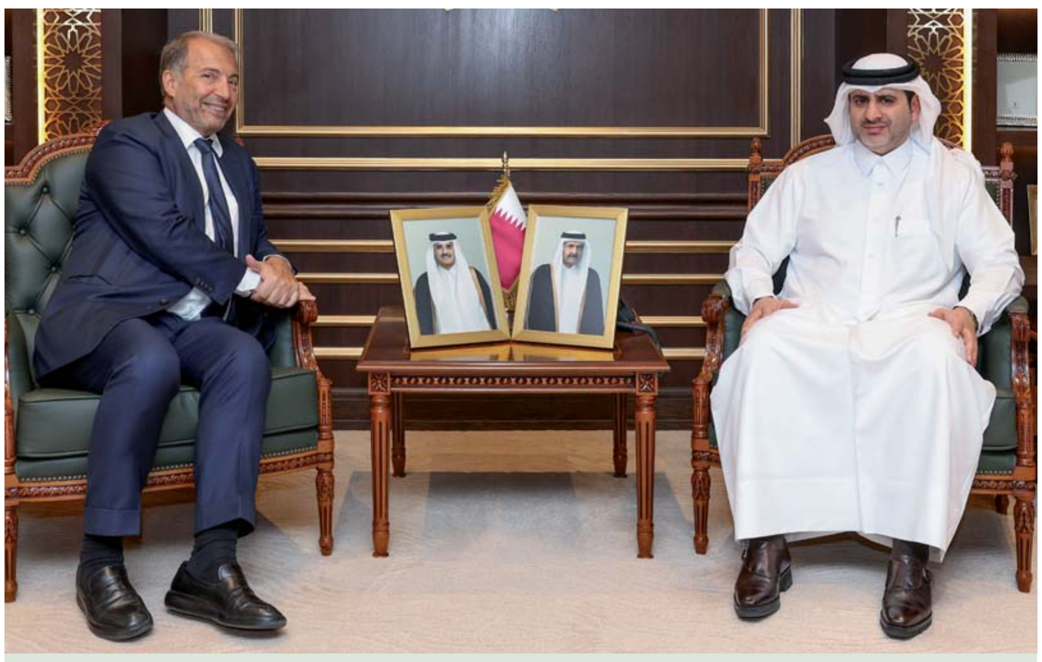


QCB Governor meets with Senior Advisor to HSBC's Group Chairman and Group CEO

Governor of the Qatar Central Bank (QCB) H E Sheikh Bandar bin Mohammed bin Saoud Al Thani met yesterday with Samir Assaf, Senior Advisor to HSBC's Group Chairman and Group CEO, along with the accompanying delegation. During the meeting, they reviewed the latest global developments in banking and finance.

Digital innovation driving growth in AI, cloud computing technologies

DEEPAK JOHN
THE PENINSULA

DOHA: Qatar's commitment to actively pursuing an economic diversification agenda has created several lucrative opportunities for investors.

The country invests substantially in AI under its National Vision 2030 while supporting research institutions like Qatar Computing Research Institute (QCRI) to advance AI adoption across healthcare, finance, and smart cities, noted Dr. Zhu Shenggao, Vice President of AI, Huawei Cloud Middle East and Central Asia in an interview with the The Peninsula.

The launch of the local large language model, Fanar, strengthens regional AI capabilities, while applications in predictive analytics, automation, and public services accelerate economic growth.

He highlighted how digital innovation is driving growth and opportunities in AI, cloud computing, and emerging technologies in Qatar and the region.

Dr. Shenggao said, cloud computing adoption is expanding rapidly as businesses modernise their IT infrastructure. Qatar's collaboration with Huawei on sovereign cloud solutions and HPC data centers supports AI, big data, and machine learning initiatives.

Further afield, the GCC region is embracing 5G, IoT, blockchain, and robotics to power smart cities, automation, and sustainable industries. These technologies enable advancements in autonomous vehicles, smart infrastructure, and remote healthcare, while blockchain facilitates secure transactions and supply chain management. Huawei Cloud implements the Everything as a Service strategy, which comprises of Infrastructure as a Service, Technology as a Service, and Expertise as a Service, he added.

Qatar invests substantially in AI under its National Vision 2030 while supporting research institutions like Qatar Computing Research Institute to advance AI adoption across healthcare, finance, and smart cities.

Cloud computing adoption is expanding rapidly as businesses modernise their IT infrastructure.

Regarding Infrastructure as a Service for global accessibility, Dr. Shenggao explained, KooVerse is Huawei Cloud's global infrastructure, offering storage, computing, networking, and security with a unified architecture across 93 availability zones in 33 regions, serving over 170 countries. Enterprises can quickly access Huawei Cloud and global markets without building their own data centers or reinvesting in basic technologies.

He further noted that Qatar fosters a startup-friendly ecosystem through Qatar Science & Technology Park (QSTP), QIA's tech investment fund, and partnerships with leaders such as Huawei to build cloud and AI infrastructure. These investments are positioning Qatar and the GCC as leaders in digital innovation, unlocking new business opportunities, driving efficiency, and shaping the future of the digital economy.

Qatar is prioritising the development of its ICT sector as it aims to transform into a knowledge-based economy in line with Qatar National Vision 2030. The country has identified six critical factors – which include national innovation strategy, high research and development (R&D) levels and diverse funding options for SMEs (small and medium enterprises) – for establishing and maintaining a successful startup ecosystem

Kazakh National Bank lowers GDP growth forecast

ALMATY: The National Bank of Kazakhstan has revised its GDP growth forecast for 2025-2026 to 4.2-5.2 percent, the central bank's press service reported recently.

"Economic growth projections for 2025 and 2026 have been slightly lowered to 4.2-5.2 percent. The revision is due to several factors, including the government's reduced forecast for oil production," the National Bank stated.

Economic growth projections for 2025 and 2026 have been slightly lowered to 4.2-5.2 percent. The revision is due to several factors, including the government's reduced forecast for oil production.

At the same time, the press service noted that strong domestic demand and a recovering oil sector will continue to support economic growth in 2025-2026.

In November last year, the National Bank projected that, under the baseline scenario, Kazakhstan's economy would expand by 4.5-5.5 percent in 2025 and by 4.6-5.6 percent in 2026.

According to the World Bank's projections, Kazakhstan's GDP will grow by 4.7 percent in 2025 and by 3.5 percent in 2026. — ***XINHUA***

QIIB launches finance offer for Ramadan in collaboration with Qatar Airways Privilege Club

THE PENINSULA

DOHA: QIIB has launched its best personal, auto, and home finance offer for its customers in celebration of the holy month of Ramadan, featuring competitive financing rates along with the chance to win prizes from a pool of 40 million bonus Avios with Qatar Airways Privilege Club.

With this special offer, which runs from March 1 to March 30, 2025, existing QIIB customers—as well as new customers who transfer their salaries and financial commitments to the bank—can benefit from personal, auto, or home financing at a competitive profit rate starting from 5%, based on their classification.

Additionally, customers availing financing during the offer duration will enter a draw and have the chance to be one among the 40 winners of 1 million bonus Avios each with Qatar Airways Privilege Club. Winners of the bonus Avios can use them for flights with Qatar Airways, oneworld® airlines and partner airlines, upgrades, extra baggage, direct bookings with Qatar Executive, packages with Qatar Airways Holidays, shopping and dining at Qatar Duty Free, bidding on Privilege Club Collection and much more. The draw is subject to the offer terms and conditions which are available on the QIIB website.

Customers who receive financing under this new offer will benefit from a grace period of up to 12 months for Qatari nationals and three months for residents, calculated within the financing tenure. Applicants can apply for financing through various channels, including QIIB's digital platforms such as mobile and online banking, or by visiting any of the bank's branch.

On the launch of QIIB's best finance offer in celebration of Ramadan, Khaled Abdul Rahman Al Shaibei **(pictured)**, Head of Business Development at QIIB, stated: "We take this opportunity to extend our warmest greetings to our customers and all Qataris and residents on the occasion of the blessed month of Ramadan. We are pleased to announce the launch of our best finance offer, carefully designed to meet our customers' expectations and financial needs. Through this offer, we are also delighted to again collaborate with Qatar Airways Privilege Club. ➔P11

GTA announces extension of tax return filing period for 2024 fiscal year

THE PENINSULA

DOHA: In conjunction with the recently launched 100% Financial Penalty Exemption Initiative, the General Tax Authority (GTA) has announced a four-month extension for the submission of tax returns for the fiscal year ending on December 31, 2024. The new deadline for filing tax returns is now August 31, 2025, instead of April 30, 2025, subject to the approved alternative accounting periods. This extension aims to provide taxpayers with additional time to complete their procedures and fulfill their tax obligations.

This extension applies to all entities and individuals subject to the provisions of the Income Tax Law No. (24) of 2018 and its amendments, including tax-exempt companies, entities owned by Qatari nationals or GCC citizens, as well as companies with non-Qatari partners. However, companies in petroleum operations and petrochemical industries are excluded from this decision and are required to submit their tax returns no later than April 30, 2025.

Reflecting the General Tax Authority's commitment to supporting taxpayers, the decision to extend the tax return filing period aligns with the 100% Financial Penalty Exemption Initiative. This provides taxpayers with a greater opportunity to benefit from both the initiative and the extension, enhancing their tax compliance in accordance with the applicable regulations.

GTA urges all taxpayers to submit their tax returns electronically through the Dhareeba Tax Portal, and remains committed to providing the necessary support to ensure tax compliance and streamline procedures.

Qatar Exchange Traded Fund
Vision. Value. Growth.

www.qetf.com.qa

QE INDEX ETF FINANCIAL STATEMENTS AND INDEPENDENT AUDITORS' REPORT
For the year ended 31 December 2024

QE INDEX ETF DISCLOSES ITS FINANCIAL STATEMENTS FOR THE YEAR ENDED 31 DECEMBER 2024

QE Index ETF discloses its financial statements as at and for the year ended 31 December 2024. The statements show that the net asset value as of 31 December 2024 amounted to QAR 418,792,108 representing QAR 10.325 per unit.

In addition, QE Index ETF is expected to pay dividends during the second quarter of 2025

INDEPENDENT AUDITOR'S REPORT TO THE UNIT HOLDERS OF QE INDEX ETF

REPORT ON THE AUDIT OF THE FINANCIAL STATEMENTS

Our opinion

In our opinion, the financial statements presents fairly, in all material respects, the financial position of QE Index ETF ("the Fund") as at 31 December 2024 and its financial performance and its cash flows for the year then ended in accordance with the IFRS Accounting Standards.

What we have audited

The Fund's financial statements comprise:

- The statement of financial position as at 31 December 2024;
- The statement of comprehensive income for the year then ended;
- The statement of changes in net assets attributable to the unit holders for the year then ended;
- The statement of cash flows for the year then ended; and
- The notes to the financial statements, which include material accounting policy information and other explanatory information.

Basis for opinion

We conducted our audit in accordance with International Standards on Auditing (ISAs). Our responsibilities under those standards are further described in the Auditor's responsibilities for the audit of the financial statements section of our report.

We believe that the audit evidence we have obtained is sufficient and appropriate to provide a basis for our opinion.

Independence

We are independent of the Fund in accordance with the International Code of Ethics for Professional Accountants (including International Independence Standards) issued by the International Ethics Standards Board for Accountants (IESBA Code) and the ethical requirements that are relevant to our audit of the financial statements in the State of Qatar. We have fulfilled our other ethical responsibilities in accordance with IESBA Code and the ethical requirements in the state of Qatar.

Our audit approach

Overview

Key audit matter | Valuation of investment securities

As part of designing our audit, we determined materiality and assessed the risks of material misstatement in the financial statements. In particular, we considered where Fund Manager made subjective judgements; for example, in respect of significant accounting estimates that involved making assumptions and considering future events that are inherently uncertain. As in all of our audits, we also addressed the risk of management override of internal controls, including among other matters consideration of whether there was evidence of bias that represented a risk of material misstatement due to fraud.

We tailored the scope of our audit in order to perform sufficient work to enable us to provide an opinion on the financial statements as a whole, taking into account the structure of the Fund, the accounting processes and controls, and the industry in which the Fund operates.

Key audit matters

Key audit matters are those matters that, in our professional judgment, were of most significance in our audit of the financial statements of the current year. These matters were addressed in the context of our audit of the financial statements as a whole, and in forming our opinion thereon, and we do not provide a separate opinion on these matters.

Key audit matter	How our audit addressed the key audit matter
Valuation of investment securities The fair value of investment securities as 31 December 2024, comprises listed equity securities, amounted to QAR 413,010,715 representing 98.36% of the total asset value of the Fund as at 31 December 2024, hence are significant within the overall context of the financial statements. Net loss from investment securities amounted to QAR 9,950,429 for the year ended 31 December 2024. The fair valuation of investment securities represents the Fund Manager's best estimate of the fair value. As described in the material accounting policies to the financial statements, the fair value has been determined in accordance with IFRS 9. Refer to note 4 for investment securities disclosure and note 6 for the net loss from investment securities disclosure.	Our audit procedures in relation to this key audit matter included the following: • Obtained Obtained an understanding of the business process related to investment management activities followed by the Fund Manager. • Tested the valuation of listed investments portfolio as at 31 December 2024, by agreeing the prices used by the Fund Manager in the valuation to independent third party sources as at 31 December 2024. • Tested the existence of listed investment portfolio by agreeing the holdings of investments to the custodian confirmation as at 31 December 2024. • Re-computed on a sample basis, the net loss from investment securities, comprising of net realized loss on sale of investment securities and net unrealized loss on revaluation of investment securities. • Evaluated the reasonableness of the financial statements disclosures in accordance with the IFRS Accounting Standards.

Responsibilities of Fund Manager and those charged with governance for the financial statements

The Fund Manager is responsible for the preparation and fair presentation of the financial statements in accordance with IFRS Accounting Standards, and for such internal control as the Fund Manager determines is necessary to enable the preparation of financial statements that are free from material misstatement, whether due to fraud or error.

In preparing the financial statements, the Fund Manager is responsible for assessing the Fund's ability to continue as a going concern, disclosing, as applicable, matters related to going concern and using the going concern basis of accounting unless the Fund Manager either intends to liquidate the Fund or to cease operations, or has no realistic alternative but to do so.

Those charged with governance are responsible for overseeing the Fund's financial reporting process..

Auditor's responsibilities for the audit of the financial statements

Our objectives are to obtain reasonable assurance about whether the financial statements as a whole are free from material misstatement, whether due to fraud or error, and to issue an auditor's report that includes our opinion. Reasonable assurance is a high level of assurance, but is not a guarantee that an audit conducted in accordance with ISAs will always detect a material misstatement when it exists. Misstatements can arise from fraud or error and are considered material if, individually or in the aggregate, they could reasonably be expected to influence the economic decisions of users taken on the basis of these financial statements.

As part of an audit in accordance with ISAs, we exercise professional judgment and maintain professional scepticism throughout the audit. We also:

- Identify and assess the risks of material misstatement of the financial statements, whether due to fraud or error, design and perform audit procedures responsive to those risks, and obtain audit evidence that is sufficient and appropriate to provide a basis for our opinion. The risk of not detecting a material misstatement resulting from fraud is higher than for one resulting from error, as fraud may involve collusion, forgery, intentional omissions, misrepresentations, or the override of internal control.
- Obtain an understanding of internal control relevant to the audit in order to design audit procedures that are appropriate in the circumstances, but not for the purpose of expressing an opinion on the effectiveness of the Fund's internal control.
- Evaluate the appropriateness of accounting policies used and the reasonableness of accounting estimates and related disclosures made by Fund Manager.
- Conclude on the appropriateness of the Fund Manager's use of the going concern basis of accounting and, based on the audit evidence obtained, whether a material uncertainty exists related to events or conditions that may cast significant doubt on the Fund's ability to continue as a going concern. If we conclude that a material uncertainty exists, we are required to draw attention in our auditor's report to the related disclosures in the financial statements or, if such disclosures are inadequate, to modify our opinion. Our conclusions are based on the audit evidence obtained up to the date of our auditor's report. However, future events or conditions may cause the Fund to cease to continue as a going concern.
- Evaluate the overall presentation, structure and content of the financial statements, including the disclosures, and whether the financial statements represent the underlying transactions and events in a manner that achieves fair presentation.

We communicate with those charged with governance regarding, among other matters, the planned scope and timing of the audit and significant audit findings, including any significant deficiencies in internal control that we identify during our audit.

We also provide those charged with governance with a statement that we have complied with relevant ethical requirements regarding independence, and to communicate with them all relationships and other matters that may reasonably be thought to bear on our independence, and where applicable, related safeguards.

From the matters communicated with those charged with governance, we determine those matters that were of most significance in the audit of the financial statements of the current year and are therefore the key audit matters. We describe these matters in our auditor's report unless law or regulation precludes public disclosure about the matter or when, in extremely rare circumstances, we determine that a matter should not be communicated in our report because the adverse consequences of doing so would reasonably be expected to outweigh the public interest benefits of such communication.

For and on behalf of PricewaterhouseCoopers – Qatar Branch
Qatar Financial Market Authority registration number 120155

Waleed Tahtamouni
Auditor's registration number 370
Doha, State of Qatar
23rd February 2025

QE INDEX ETF STATEMENT OF COMPREHENSIVE INCOME
For the year ended 31 December 2024

	2024 QAR	2023 QAR
Income		
Net (loss) / gain from investment securities	**(9,950,429)**	6,129,151
Dividend income	**24,247,614**	18,872,915
Total income	**14,297,185**	25,002,066
Operating expenses		
Management fees	**(653,883)**	(709,689)
Administration fees	**(386,900)**	(388,618)
Custodian fees	**(180,086)**	(176,948)
Brokerage fees	**(108,127)**	(108,314)
Other operating expenses	**(685,643)**	(678,739)
Total operating expenses	**(2,014,639)**	(2,062,308)
Operating profit	**12,282,546**	22,939,758
Change in net assets attributable to the unit holders	**12,282,546**	22,939,758

QE INDEX ETF STATEMENT OF FINANCIAL POSITION
As at 31 December 2024

	2024 QAR	2023 QAR
Assets		
Cash and cash equivalents	**6,900,409**	1,011,306
Investment securities	**413,010,715**	426,012,263
Total assets	**419,911,124**	427,023,569
Liabilities		
Payables and accrued expenses	**1,119,016**	987,195
Total liabilities	**1,119,016**	987,195
Net assets attributable to the unit holders	**418,792,108**	426,036,374
Number of units in issue (Units)	**40,562,310**	40,637,310
Net asset value per unit (QAR)	**10.325**	10.484

STATEMENT OF CHANGES IN NET ASSETS ATTRIBUTABLE TO THE UNIT HOLDERS
For the year ended 31 December 2024

	2024		2023	
	Number of units	**QAR**	Number of units	QAR
Balance at 1 January	**40,637,310**	**426,036,374**	40,687,310	422,260,229
Change in net assets attributable to the unit holders	**-**	**12,282,546**	-	22,939,758
Dividends paid (Note 9)	**-**	**(18,739,787)**		(18,727,663)
Contributions and redemptions by unit holders:				
Issue of redeemable units during the year	**50,000**	**461,625**	25,000	256,675
Redemption of redeemable units during the year	**(125,000)**	**(1,248,650)**	(75,000)	(692,625)
Transactions with the unit holders	**(75,000)**	**(787,025)**	(50,000)	(435,950)
Balance at 31 December	**40,562,310**	**418,792,108**	40,637,310	426,036,374

QE INDEX ETF STATEMENT OF CASH FLOWS
or the year ended 31 December 2024

	2024 QAR	2023 QAR
Operating activities		
Change in net assets attributable to the unit holders	**12,282,546**	22,939,758
Adjustments for:		
Net unrealized loss / (gain) on revaluation of investment securities	**8,638,729**	(7,674,709)
Dividend income	**(24,247,614)**	(18,872,915)
Operating loss before changes in operating assets and liabilities	**(3,326,339)**	(3,607,866)
Changes in:		
Investment securities	**4,362,819**	3,740,509
Payables and accrued expenses	**131,821**	(400,784)
Dividend received	**24,247,614**	18,872,915
Net cash flows generated from operating activities	**25,415,915**	18,604,774
Financing activities		
Proceeds from issue of redeemable units	**461,625**	256,675
Payment against redemption of units	**(1,248,650)**	(692,625)
Dividends paid	**(18,739,787)**	(18,727,663)
Net cash flows used in financing activities	**(19,526,812)**	(19,163,613)
Net increase / (decrease) in cash and cash equivalents	**5,889,103**	(558,839)
Cash and cash equivalents at the 1 January	**1,011,306**	1,570,145
Cash and cash equivalents as at 31 December	**6,900,409**	1,011,306

These financial statements were approved by the Committee members as authorized by the Board of Directors on 23 February 2025 and were signed on its behalf by:

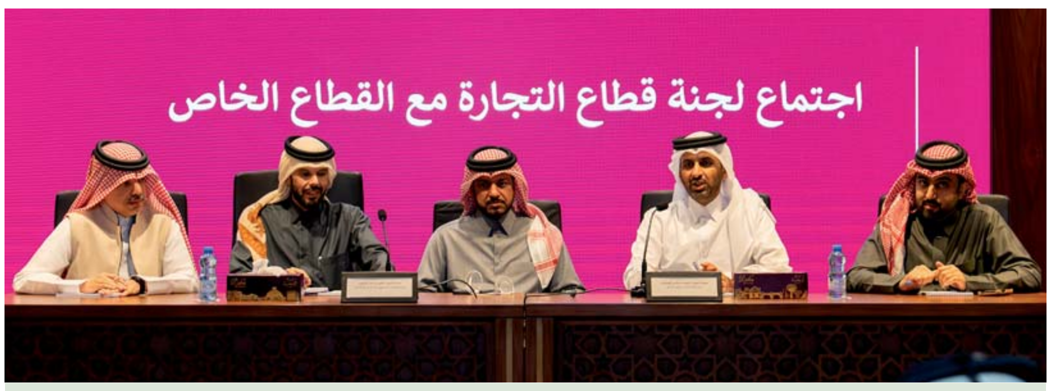
Fawad Ishaq
Chief Treasury & Investment Officer
Doha Bank Q.P.S.C.
On behalf of the QE Index ETF ("QETF")

Commerce Sector Committee discusses business environment challenges

THE PENINSULA

DOHA: The Commerce Sector Committee at the Ministry of Commerce and Industry held a meeting with private sector representatives at the Ministry's headquarters in Lusail to discuss the challenges facing the business environment and assess implications for the commerce sector.

The meeting was chaired by Ayed Menahi Al Qahtani, Assistant Undersecretary for Commerce Affairs and Chairman of the Commerce Sector Committee, alongside committee members and representatives from Qatar Chamber.



Assistant Undersecretary for Commerce Affairs and Chairman of the Commerce Sector Committee, Ayed Menahi Al Qahtani with other officials during the meeting.

During the meeting, participants reviewed proposals from private sector representatives focusing on reaching solutions to improve the business environment and foster commercial growth. Discussions also focused on enhancing cooperation between the public and private sectors to overcome challenges and achieve sustainable growth in the commerce sector.

The Committee was established in 2024 by a decision of H E Sheikh Faisal bin Thani bin Faisal Al Thani, Minister of Commerce and Industry; and is chaired by Ayed Menahi Al Qahtani. Committee members include representatives from Ministry of Transport, the General Authority of Customs, Qatar General Organisation for Standards and Metrology, the General Tax Authority, the Free Zones Authority, Economic Zones Company (Manateq), and Ministry of Commerce and Industry.

The committee is responsible for organising meetings with the private sector to identify challenges, gather proposals, and assess implications for the business environment and the economy at large. It aims to strengthen partnerships between the public and private sectors, ensure transparency in regulatory measures, and build trust among stakeholders.

During the meeting, participants reviewed proposals from private sector representatives focusing on reaching solutions to improve the business environment and foster commercial growth.

Additionally, the committee provides recommendations and proposals based on the outcomes of organised workshops and meetings, ensuring alignment with economic development priorities and business environment improvements.

China's 2025 GDP growth goal shows confidence in stable

BERLIN: China's GDP growth target of around 5 percent for 2025 sheds light on its confidence in economic stability and its commitment to high-quality development, a global consultancy executive has said.

The policy measures, outlined in the government work report submitted to the National People's Congress on Wednesday, support China's ongoing economic transformation and create new opportunities for foreign enterprises, Denis Depoux, global managing director at Roland Berger, told Xinhua.

"China's growing influence in the global economic landscape will continue to create new opportunities for international businesses." — ***XINHUA***

US economy adds 151,000 jobs in February 2025

WASHINGTON: The labor market picked up 151,000 jobs in February, a solid pace, despite a massive layoff among federal workers that began to show up in the data.

The unemployment rate ticked up to 4.1 percent, extending low levels that have marked the past few years.

Federal government payrolls lost 10,000 jobs in February. The jobs report data was collected the second week of February, when Elon Musk's US DOGE Service was beginning to cut agency workforces. In early February, some federal contracts and grants had been frozen or cut due to executive orders, which led to private-sector layoffs among government contractors and non-profits. "This is an extraordinary economy with good momentum. That's the single best indicator of the future," said Justin Wolfers, an economist at the University of Michigan. "But there's a tremendous rise in uncertainty. ... If a bunch of CEOs or families pull back, that's going to create what could be the start of a recession." Job gains came in slightly lower than analysts' expectations of 170,000 new jobs in February but were muted by workers impacted by severe winter weather and federal government layoffs.


The newly formed Department of Government Efficiency has axed jobs, slashed federal spending and scrapped contracts. (AFP)

President Donald Trump touted February's jobs numbers in remarks at the Oval Office on Friday, trumpeting job creation in the private sector, especially manufacturing - which added 10,000 jobs last month - and "big gains for native-born workers" compared to foreign-born workers.

"During the first full month in office, we've not only stopped the manufacturing collapse, but we've begun to rapidly reverse it and get major gains," Trump said. Major stock indexes responded with muted enthusiasm early Friday to the jobs gains, a welcome sign for the Federal Reserve, which aims to cool the labor market without triggering a recession. The report also offered a respite from trade policy developments that have distressed Wall Street this week.

Average hourly wage growth slowed in February compared with the prior month, rising by 0.3 percent, to $35.93 an hour, but outpacing inflation in a boost to workers' pocketbooks. — ***THE WASHINGTON POST***

Federation of GCC Chambers launches Tawasul initiative to enhance public-private sector integration

RIYADH: The Federation of GCC Chambers (FGCC Chambers), with support from the General Secretariat of the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC), launched the Tawasul initiative, with the aim of enhancing cooperation and integration between the public and private sectors.

The initiative contributes to introducing the private sector to available investment opportunities, enabling it to benefit from government incentives.

In addition, the initiative seeks to discuss economic integration projects and address the challenges that hinder the growth of trade and investment between the GCC countries.

In comments, FGCC Chambers Secretary-General Saleh bin Hamad Al Sharqi explained that the initiative aims to increase the volume of trade exchange and inter-investments, address challenges facing the private sector, enhance the benefits of government initiatives, and create new initiatives to support the Gulf business environment, thereby strengthening economic integration between the GCC countries.

He indicated that the initiative will be implemented in cooperation with member federations and chambers through organising events, workshops and seminars to discuss investment opportunities, facilitate the exchange of expertise between the private sector and relevant parties, and hold an economic seminar that brings together Gulf officials and investors for direct discussions on challenges and solutions to enhance Gulf investments.

The initiative seeks to discuss economic integration projects and address the challenges that hinder the growth of trade and investment between the GCC countries.

Al Sharqi noted that the initiative responds to several challenges facing the private sector in the GCC countries, including limited awareness of available investment opportunities, the lack of a unified platform connecting the private sector with government agencies, and the failure to provide tailored solutions for each economic sector. — ***QNA***

QIIB launches finance offer for Ramadan in collaboration with Qatar Airways Privilege Club

FROM PAGE 9

"QIIB's best finance offer, launched in celebration of Ramadan, caters to the needs of various customer segments—whether they are seeking personal, auto, or home finance. The offer provides competitive benefits, flexible terms, and streamlined financing procedures, with the added convenience of digital channels for a faster and more seamless customer experience."

Al Shaibei explained: "Along with offering competitive financing benefits such as profit rates and grace periods, QIIB's special Ramadan finance offer provides an exceptional opportunity for customers to win from a total prize-pool of 40 million bonus Avios. A draw will be held at the end of the campaign, selecting 40 winners, each receiving 1 million bonus Avios with Qatar Airways Privilege Club. The winning members can use their Avios for rewards of their choice with Qatar Airways Privilege Club, adding significant value to our best finance offer in celebration of Ramadan."

Thomas Vadakedath, Senior Vice President Loyalty at Qatar Airways, stated: "We deeply value the partnership between Qatar Airways Privilege Club and QIIB, and are committed to bringing our loyal members exciting partner offers."

Mexico says up to 90 percent of exports to US can enjoy tariff relief

MEXICO CITY: Mexico's government said that as much as 90% of exports to the US could benefit from the tariff relief deal the two nations reached Thursday, significantly reducing the risks to a slowing economy that is heavily dependent on trade with its northern neighbor.

US President Donald Trump exempted Mexican and Canadian goods covered by the North American trade deal known as the USMCA from 25% tariffs until April 2.

That relief will apply to more than half of Mexico's exports to the US, and companies using a different exemption called the "most-favored nation" rate will be able to access that benefit quickly and easily before April, Economy Minister Marcelo Ebrard said Friday.

"We estimate that they will account for around 85% to 90% of Mexico's foreign trade with the US by April," Ebrard said alongside President Claudia Sheinbaum at her daily morning press conference.

Trump agreed to the tariff relief after speaking to Sheinbaum on Thursday, just days after the levies had gone into effect.

Sheinbaum told reporters after the call that she highlighted her government's efforts to help stem the flow of illegal drugs across the US border, saying Mexico had made progress in meeting Trump's demands.

She also warned Trump that Mexico would have had no choice but take retaliatory measures if the tariffs remained in place.

Ebrard said Mexican officials will meet with counterparts from the US Trade Representative's office next week to continue negotiations. He said Trump's proposed duties on steel and aluminum wouldn't be justified because Mexico imports more of the metals from the US than the US imports from Mexico.

Mexico will start working with companies, mainly in the automotive industry, that will not benefit from the tariff relief deal, Ebrard said.

Exports from those companies to the US account for between 10 percent and 12 percent of the total, he said, adding that Mexico's government will "see what measures we take" after meeting with their representatives.

About 49% of US imports from Mexico were exempt from duties under the USMCA last year, according to a Bloomberg Economics analysis of US Census Bureau trade data. Another 41% of imports have until Trump's latest order entered with minimal duties under the so-called "most-favored nation" rate, without having to apply under the USMCA.

If those goods are no longer allowed to trade under preferential rates, providers may look to switch to compliance with the USMCA to avoid the 25% tariffs.

At the very least, 10% of goods Mexico exports to the US will be subject to Trump's tariffs, according to Bloomberg Economics. — ***THE WASHINGTON POST / BLOOMBERG***

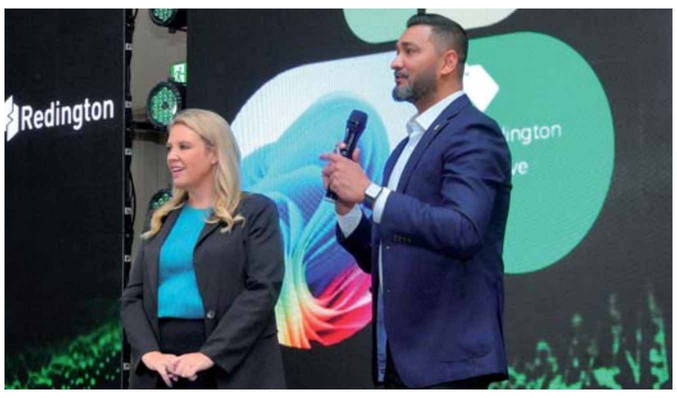
Redington Gulf launches Reboot 2025 initiative

DOHA: Redington Gulf, a leading IT distributor has unveiled Reboot 2025, an initiative bringing together the PC ecosystem working with Windows. As Windows 10 approaches its end of support on October 14, 2025, businesses are at increasing risk of security vulnerabilities and diminished performance by continuing to rely on outdated PCs. To address this, Redington is empowering the channel ecosystem across MEA to drive awareness and help their customers seamlessly transition to Windows 11 Pro.

Ronan Symth, Device Partner GTM Director, CEMA, Microsoft commented, "Reboot 2025 will unite Redington, OEMs, Intel, Microsoft, and partners to expedite the Windows 10 End of Support refresh before October 14, 2025. This initiative will help customers understand the risks of missing this deadline, highlight Windows 11's productivity and security innovations, and guide them in selecting the right devices, including AI PC and Copilot+ options."

"As the largest PC distributor in the region, Redington has taken responsibility for helping the channel ecosystem understand the implications of Windows 10 end of support for businesses. Additionally, partners need to advocate the benefits of AI PCs and the positive impact AI PCs will have on businesses across the region," said Jeetendra Berry, President – End Point Solutions Group MEA, Redington Gulf.

With AI-driven capabilities, including Microsoft Copilot, Windows 11 Pro is designed to enhance productivity, streamline workflows, and automate repetitive tasks, enabling businesses to focus on more strategic activities.



Officials at the launch.

"At Microsoft, we are committed to collaborating with Redington and partners across the region to ensure that businesses are fully prepared for the future, with the right tools to drive success and innovation." said Frangiskos Lambrinos, Device Partner Sales Lead, MEA, Microsoft.

This initiative is a collaboration between Microsoft and Redington, working together to equip businesses with the tools and knowledge they need to embrace Windows 11 Pro and leverage its AI-powered features to drive success.